

Stylistic Transformations

C2 · Renan the Teacher — English Language Academy

1. BRIEF EXPLANATION

At C2, you can re-express the same underlying idea in multiple grammatical forms, shifting tone and register without changing the core meaning. This is a key skill for editing your own writing and adapting to different audiences.

- a) Active to passive rephrasing at high nuance — beyond the basic transformation, choose active or passive deliberately based on what should be emphasized, and how formal/impersonal the text should sound.

Active (direct, agent-focused): The board rejected the proposal.

Passive (formal, result-focused, agent optional): The proposal was rejected (by the board). / The proposal was rejected, a decision that surprised many. (agent omitted entirely — common in formal/academic writing when the actor is unknown or unimportant)

- b) Multiple ways to re-express the same idea with tone changes — the same content can be delivered as a blunt statement, a hedged academic claim, a formal announcement, or a rhetorical question, depending on audience and purpose.

Blunt: The plan failed.

Hedged/academic: It could be argued that the plan did not achieve its intended outcomes.

Formal/official: The initiative did not meet its stated objectives.

Rhetorical: Can anyone really claim that this plan succeeded?

- c) Grammar-driven style shifts — using specific grammatical choices to signal register:
 - - Nominalization + passive = formal/academic/legal ("The implementation of the policy was delayed" vs. "They delayed implementing the policy").
 - - Modal hedging (may, might, could, it would seem that) = cautious, academic tone.
 - - Contractions, phrasal verbs, and direct imperatives = informal/conversational tone.
 - - Cleft sentences and fronting = emphatic, persuasive, rhetorical tone.

Mastering these transformations means you can take one idea and dial its formality, distance, and emphasis up or down at will.

2. EXAMPLES

- 1. The committee approved the budget. → The budget was approved (by

the committee).

- 2. They messed up the schedule badly. → The scheduling was severely mismanaged.
- 3. I think the plan won't work. → It could be argued that the plan is unlikely to succeed.
- 4. We're cutting costs next quarter. → Cost reductions will be implemented in the next quarter.
- 5. Nobody knows exactly why the project failed. → The precise cause of the project's failure remains unclear.
- 6. He clearly lied to the board. → It would appear that the information presented to the board was not entirely accurate.
- 7. Fix this now! → This issue requires immediate attention.
- 8. The team is incredibly talented. → The team's talent is beyond question.
- 9. Sales dropped a lot last quarter. → A significant decline in sales was recorded last quarter.
- 10. Everyone agrees the policy failed. → There is broad consensus that the policy did not achieve its objectives.

3. COMMON MISTAKES

- 1. Incorrect: The proposal was rejected by they.

Correct: The proposal was rejected by them.

Why: After "by" in a passive sentence, use the object pronoun ("them"), not the subject pronoun.

- 2. Incorrect: It could be argue that the plan failed.

Correct: It could be argued that the plan failed.

Why: The passive hedge needs the past participle ("argued"), not the base form.

- 3. Incorrect: The implementation of the policy delayed.

Correct: The implementation of the policy was delayed.

Why: Nominalized subjects still need a full passive verb ("was delayed"), not just the past participle alone.

- 4. Incorrect: A significant decline of sales was recorded.

Correct: A significant decline in sales was recorded.

Why: "Decline" collocates with "in," not "of," when referring to a drop in a measurable quantity.

- 5. Incorrect: There is broad consensus what the policy failed.

Correct: There is broad consensus that the policy failed.

Why: "Consensus" is followed by "that + clause," not "what."

4. EXERCISES

- A. Gap-fill (complete the more formal/academic rephrasing)
- 1. They lost a lot of money. → A substantial ____ (loss) was incurred.
- 2. Nobody really knows why it happened. → The reason ____ remains unclear.
- 3. I think the results are wrong. → It ____ be argued that the results are flawed.
- 4. We will announce the decision tomorrow. → The decision ____ (announce) tomorrow.
- 5. Everyone agrees this is a problem. → There is broad ____ that this is a problem.
- 6. The team messed up the launch. → The launch ____ (severely mismanage).
- B. Rewrite / Transformation (rewrite each blunt/informal sentence in a more formal, hedged, or passive register)
- 1. The manager screwed up the budget.
- 2. I'm pretty sure the plan won't work.
- 3. They're cutting jobs next month.
- 4. The report is full of mistakes.
- 5. Nobody bothered to check the numbers.
- 6. Fix the website — it's broken.
- C. Error Correction
- 1. It could be argue that the results are inconclusive.
- 2. The decision was announcing yesterday.
- 3. There is broad consensus what needs to change.
- 4. A sharp decline of revenue was reported.
- 5. The proposal was rejected by they.
- 6. The implementation delayed for months.
- D. Guided Production
- 1. Take a blunt, informal sentence you might say to a friend, and rewrite it in formal/academic register.
- 2. Write one sentence using nominalization + passive to describe a change or event (e.g., in the news, at work).
- 3. Write one hedged academic sentence using "It could be argued that..." about a topic you have an opinion on.
- 4. Write the same idea twice: once as a direct statement, once as a rhetorical question with the same underlying meaning.

5. ANSWER KEY

- A. Gap-fill
- 1. loss
- 2. why it happened / for this
- 3. could
- 4. will be announced
- 5. consensus
- 6. was severely mismanaged
- B. Rewrite / Transformation (sample answers)
- 1. The budget was significantly mismanaged by the manager. / Serious mismanagement of the budget occurred under the manager's supervision.
- 2. It could be argued that the plan is unlikely to succeed.
- 3. Job cuts will be implemented next month.

- 4. The report contains a considerable number of errors.
- 5. The figures were not adequately checked.
- 6. The website requires immediate attention, as it is currently non-functional.
- C. Error Correction
 - 1. It could be argued that the results are inconclusive.
 - 2. The decision was announced yesterday.
 - 3. There is broad consensus about what needs to change. / ...on what needs to change.
 - 4. A sharp decline in revenue was reported.
 - 5. The proposal was rejected by them.
 - 6. The implementation was delayed for months.
- D. Guided Production (sample answers)
 - 1. Informal: "This meeting was a total waste of time." → Formal: "The meeting did not yield any substantive outcomes."
 - 2. The postponement of the launch was announced without prior notice, catching many stakeholders off guard.
 - 3. It could be argued that remote work has fundamentally changed how companies measure productivity.
 - 4. Direct: "The policy failed." / Rhetorical: "Can this policy really be considered a success by any reasonable measure?"